



DRONE REGULATIONS 1.0

After working on appropriate drone regulations for several years, the Ministry of Civil Aviation has formulated an all digital process for drone operations in the country

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The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has been busy formulating the regulations for drones for years now, and there is a reason for this. The drone platforms are rapidly evolving, and the regulations have to keep up with the pace of these advancements. The drone regulations in other countries are also in a constant state of flux, and the International Civil Aviation Organization, a body responsible for codifying the principles and techniques of international air navigation, has no suggested stands at this point of time. The regulations are rolling out along with a Digital Sky Platform, a national level unmanned traffic management system, that streamlines the entire process of drone operations. There is a one time requirement for registering each drone, pilot and owner through the platform. Some drone flights require a pilot license, and these have to be renewed periodically. The regulations are aimed at creating a healthy drone ecosystem in India.

The Union Minister of Civil Aviation, Suresh Prabhu announced the regulations on 27 August, 2018. "Today we start an exciting new

chapter in India's aviation history by allowing commercial use of drones. I am sure that many new and exciting applications will emerge that will propel India's economy forward. Our progressive regulations will encourage a vast Made in India drone industry," Prabhu said. Jayant Sinha, Minister of State for Civil Aviation said, "We want to establish a world-leading drone ecosystem. These regulations firmly place us among the global leaders. Our policy roadmap will certainly provide a strong impetus to all players in the drone ecosystem. We hope that these initiatives will enable us to create a vibrant new industry."

THE PROCEDURES

The regulations detail the procedure for flying a drone in India. There are two ways to get a drone, either import it, or buy it locally. If the drone is imported, it requires an Equipment Type Approval (ETA) from the department of telecom, which is for using the frequencies for drone control. The approval is granted to a particular make and model of a drone. If purchasing locally, the buyer has to make sure that the particular model has the approval from the department of telecom. Once

the drone is obtained, the user or pilot has to get a Unique Identification Number (UIN) for each drone. The specifications of the drone, the intended base of operations, the PAN number of the pilot are some of the documents necessary to get the UIN. The submission of the UIN has to be done through the Digital Sky Platform, which will be made live on the DGCA website. The UIN will be allocated within two days of the application.

After that, the operator is required to get the Unmanned Aircraft Operator Permit (UAOP).

The drones are categorised into five classes, depending on their weights. This weight includes any additional payloads or equipment attached to the drone. Nano drones are less than 250 grams in weight. Micro drones weigh between 250 grams and 2 kg. Small drones are between 2 to 25 kg, medium drones are between 25 to 150 kg, while large drones are heavier than 150 kg. Nano drone flights under 50 feet do not need a UAOP. Micro drone flights below 200 feet also do not need a UAOP, but the operator should inform the local police 24 hours before the flight. The UAOP will be valid for a period of five years at a time, is non